

## Module 1 · Start here

# The sounds of French

Vowels English doesn't have, silent letters, linking, rhythm — and what's different in Canadian French.

## ● YOU'LL BE ABLE TO

- ✓ Hear and produce u vs ou, é vs è, and the three nasal vowels
- ✓ Predict which final letters are silent
- ✓ Make the obligatory liaisons and elisions
- ✓ Speak with French rhythm: even syllables, stress at the end of each group

| Spelling                          | Sound                             | Examples                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| an, am, en, em                    | [ɑ̃] (Quebec often closer to [ã]) | enfant, temps, chambre, ensemble<br>child, time, bedroom, together                          |
| on, om                            | [ɔ̃]                              | bon, nom, maison, nombre<br>good, name, house, number                                       |
| in, im, ain, ein, (y)en after i/é | [ɛ̃]                              | vin, important, pain, plein, bien, européen<br>wine, important, bread, full, well, European |
| un, um                            | [œ̃] or [ɛ̃]                      | un, lundi, parfum<br>a / one, Monday, perfume                                               |

| Written                          | Said            | What's silent                                   |
|----------------------------------|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| ils parlent<br>they speak        | [il paʁl]       | -ent                                            |
| les enfants<br>the children      | [le.zɑ̃.fɑ̃]    | final -ts (the s of les is linked)              |
| un petit garçon<br>a little boy  | [œ̃.pti.ɡaʁsɔ̃] | final t, and the e of petit in speech           |
| un sac, la mer<br>a bag, the sea | [sak] [mɛʁ]     | nothing — C and R are pronounced                |
| six, dix<br>six, ten             | [sis] [dis]     | said alone; before a consonant: six livres [si] |

## ● KEY PHRASES

### Je voudrais un café.

I'd like a coffee. (five even beats, stress on -fé)

### La fin de semaine, je travaille dans un restaurant.

On weekends, I work in a restaurant. (rise on -maine, fall on -rant)

### un bon vin blanc

a good white wine (all four nasal)

### Il est canadien. Elle est canadienne.

He's Canadian. She's Canadian. (nasal vs not)

### Ils sont deux.

There are two of them. (no liaison: s-sound, not z)

### J'habite chez eux depuis un an.

I've been living with them for a year.

### Bonjour, je m'appelle Sara. J'habite à Montréal.

Hello, my name is Sara. I live in Montreal.

### Mon enfant a un bon ami canadien.

My child has a good Canadian friend. (nasals + liaison)

### Ils ont deux enfants, mais ils sont très occupés.

They have two children, but they're very busy.

### Elle arrive à huit heures avec elle.

She arrives at eight with her. (enchaînement)

## ● AVOID THESE MISTAKES

### X Pronouncing the s in Paris, trois, vous

Saying final letters is the most common beginner error and can make words unrecognisable.

### ✓ Final consonants silent (except C, R, F, L)

### X tu said like English "too"

"too" is tout (all) — a different word.

### ✓ Lips rounded, tongue forward: [ty]

### X ils parlent with "-ent" pronounced

The verb ending -ent is always silent.

### ✓ [il paʁl]

### X Pronouncing the h in hôtel

French h is never pronounced.

### ✓ [otɛl], and l'hôtel

### X Stressing the first syllable: RES-taurant

English word stress makes French hard to follow.

### ✓ Even syllables, stress at the end: res-tau-RANT

### X vous avez with a gap

Pronoun + verb liaison is obligatory.

### ✓ vous avez [vu.za.ve]

### X je aime, le hôpital

Elision is compulsory before a vowel or mute h.

### ✓ j'aime, l'hôpital

## ● TIP

Clap the syllables while you say a sentence. If some claps feel much longer than others, you're stressing English-style.